

Relating Anti-Uniqueness and Non-honorificity to Definiteness Marking in Magahi

Aidan Sharma & Jiayuan Chen

aidan.sharma@rutgers.edu & jiayuan.c@rutgers.edu

SULA-TripleA 2026

May 12-15, 2026



Definite Markers in Bare Noun Languages

- In many languages, definites can be expressed as both bare nouns (BNs) or nouns with a definite marker.
- Typically, the definite marker is not used with ‘larger-situation unique’ definites.¹
- *Question:* Is this a kind of familiar/unique distinction (Schwarz 2009).

(1) Vietnamese

a. *cái máy ảnh*

CLF camera

‘the camera’

b. (*#cái*) *mặt trăng*

#CLF moon

‘the moon’

(2) Akan

a. *papa nó*

man DEF

‘the man’

b. *awia (#nó)*

sun #DEF

‘the sun’

¹Simpson (2005); Simpson & Biswas (2016); Owusu (2022); Yip et al. (2023); Beryl Bui p.c. ▶

Definite Markers in Bare Noun Languages

There are two main proposals for how to explain the distribution of the BNs and definite marker.

- 1 Owusu (2022) proposes the Akan definite marker has an **anti-uniqueness presupposition**.

- $\llbracket \text{nó}_y \rrbracket^g = \lambda P \lambda x \lambda s : x = g(y) \wedge \underline{\exists s' s \leq s' | \{x \mid P(x)(s')\}| > 1} . P(x)(s)$

- 2 Yip et al. (2023) propose that definite BNs in Cantonese and Bangla are **quasi-names**.

- Similar to English *Mom*.

Non-honorificity

- In addition to anti-uniqueness effects, these definite markers often trigger a non-honorific interpretation.²

(3) Vietnamese

cái chủ tịch nước

CLF president country

‘the president’ (derogatory)

(4) Akan

Ghana mànpàníń nó

Ghana president DEF

‘the Ghana president’ (derogatory)

²Forson (2022); Beryl Bui p.c.

Demonstratives

- Anti-uniqueness and non-honorificity effects are well attested in demonstratives cross-linguistically.³

(5) English

the/#that sun

(6) German

Diese Politiker sind (doch) alle korrupt/#fleißig!
those politicians are but all corrupt/#hardworking

‘All *those politicians* are corrupt/#hardworking, aren’t they?’

³Dayal & Jiang (2021); Ahn (2025); Averintseva-Klisch (2016)

Demonstratives

- These non-honorific uses also include affective uses.⁴

(7) English (spoken by a nurse to a patient)

How's that toe?

⁴Ahn (2017); Lakoff (1974); Potts & Schwarz (2010)

Overview of Our Talk

- Magahi (Eastern Indo-Aryan) has both definite BNs and definites marked by $-wā$.
- $-wā$ definites are associated with anti-uniqueness and non-honorificity.

Proposal:

- Definites marked by $-wā$ are indexed definites.⁵
- The presence of an index gives rise to anti-uniqueness and non-honorificity pragmatically.
 - 1 Anti-uniqueness as structural economy: indexed definites are dis-preferred when the index is referentially and pragmatically irrelevant.⁶
 - 2 Non-honorificity as directness: indexed definites are more direct, making them less polite in a pragmatic theory of honorification.⁷

⁵Schwarz (2009); Jenks (2015, 2018); Jenks & Konate (2022).

⁶Blumberg (2020); Ahn (2025); Schlenker (2005)

⁷Wang (2023)

Magahi -wā

- Magahi has a definite marker -wā (allomorphs: -bā/-(i)yā/(i)yā̃/-ā/mā).
- Magahi also has definite BNs.
 - Usually for unique or honored referents.

(8) a. *kut-wā*
dog-DEF
‘the dog’

b. *admi-yā*
man-DEF
‘the man’

(9) a. *rāspati-#yā*
president-#DEF
‘the president’

b. *suraj-#wā*
sun-#DEF
‘the sun’

-wā and (Quasi-)names

- Magahi (quasi-)names do not need to be BNs.
- Usually, *-wā* is used for referents who are close friends of the speaker and/or younger than the speaker.

(10) a. *Ram-mā*
Ram-DEF

‘Ram’ (if Ram is younger than
the speaker)

b. *Rām*
Ram

‘Ram’ (if Ram is older than
the speaker)

(11) a. *bhai-wā*
brother-DEF

‘brother’ (for a younger
brother)

b. *bhaiyā*
brother

‘brother’ (for an older brother)

-wā and Quasi-names

- -wā is also not used with “unique” superlatives.

(12) *duniyā ke sab se tej ādmi-#yā*
world GEN all than smart man-#DEF
‘the world’s smartest man’

-wā and Quasi-names

- BNs also behave differently from (quasi-)names semantically w.r.t. rigidity.
- Only BNs have *de dicto* and counterfactual uses (cf. Yip et al. 2023).

(13) CONTEXT: You thought Biden (who is from Delaware) was the president, but you are informed Trump (who is from New York) is actually the president.

hamrā laglā hai ki rāspati Delaware state ke hai
1SG.OBL seemed AUX COMP **president** Delaware state GEN is

‘I thought that the president was from Delaware.’

-wā and Quasi-names

- (14) CONTEXT: Candidate A lost the election last year. This year, he was found to have committed a murder.

agar ham okrā liye vote karitai hal, to rāspati khuni ādmi
if 1SG 3SG.OBL for vote did AUX TOP **president** killer person
hote hal
would.be COP

‘If we had voted for him, the president would be a murderer.’

- (15) CONTEXT: Your mom is the shortest woman in all the surrounding villages, so if your dad had married any other woman then your mom would’ve been tall.

agar bābu-ji dosar aurat se sādī karthin hal, to #(hamni
if dad-HON second woman INSTR wedding did COP TOP **1PL**
ke) mai-yā lambā hote hal
GEN mom-DEF tall would.be COP

‘If dad had married another woman, #(our) mom would be tall.’

-wā and Quasi-names

BNs in Magahi $\neq$ quasi-names.

- (Quasi-)names don't need to be bare.
- (Quasi-)names are rigid; “unique” BNs are not.
- “Unique” superlatives are also BNs and unlikely to be names.⁸

⁸Coppock (2024)

Magahi -wā and Anti-uniqueness

- So, Magahi BNs are not quasi-names. But, -wā is anti-unique.
- We propose that this anti-uniqueness is pragmatic, rather than presuppositional.
- Changing the context to include multiple suns, moons, presidents, etc. allows for the use of -wā with “unique” nouns.

- (16) *jaun jaun des me ham geliai, (har des-wā ke) raspati-yā*
REL RED country in 1SG went every country-DEF GEN president-DEF
dunni hal
wealthy was

‘Whichever country I went to, the president was rich.’

- But, Dayal & Jiang (2021) propose that even if the set of situations under consideration for an anti-uniqueness presupposition is determined pragmatically, the anti-uniqueness requirement can still be presuppositional.

Magahi -wā and Anti-uniqueness

- Another reason to think anti-uniqueness is pragmatic is that speakers can “ignore” it for pragmatic purposes.
- For example, -wā can be used with unique nouns to show annoyance or contempt.

(17) *ham dhup-wā me nai jaibo*
1SG sunlight-DEF in NEG go

‘I won’t go in the sun(light).’ + The speaker is annoyed.

Magahi -wā and Non-honorificity

- Recall that -wā is only attached to the names of referents younger or of lower/equal social status than the speaker.
- Because of this, when used with an older referent, it is interpreted as disrespectful/contemptful.

(18) *Ram-mā await hai.* (Alok 2022)
Ram-DEF coming AUX

‘Ram is coming.’ + The speaker disrespects Ram.

- But, it can also be used affectively.

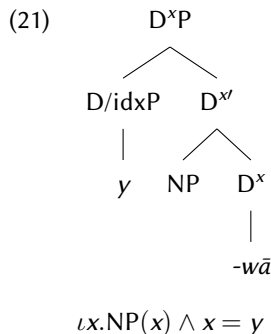
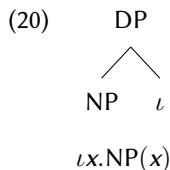
(19) *Maṣṭar-wā ail-thi(n).* (Alok & Ojaswee 2024)
teacher-DEF come-HON

‘The teacher came.’ + The speaker shows affection/intimacy with the teacher.

Proposal

Proposal:

- $-w\bar{a}$ definites have an index argument, while BN definites do not.⁹
- We adopt the syntax proposed by Jenks & Konate (2022).¹⁰



⁹Schwarz (2009); Jenks (2015, 2018); Jenks & Konate (2022); Chierchia (1998)

¹⁰This is a slight simplification of the Magahi facts. See Sharma (2025) for more discussion of the syntax of $-w\bar{a}$ definites.

-wā and familiarity

- -wā is licensed by weak familiarity (Roberts 2003)

(22) *Kut-#(wā) saṛak pār karaile chaho hai.*
dog-DEF road on cross want AUX

‘The dog wants to cross the road.’

- Also required for strong familiarity: anaphoric & donkey definites¹¹

(23) *Klās me e-go laṛkā au laṛki hai. Laṛka-#(wā) se kal milaliai.*
class LOC one-CLF **boy** and girl are **boy-DEF** with y.day met

‘There are a boy and a girl in class. I met the boy yesterday.’

(24) *Agar kisān ke pās gadhā hai, to u gadha-#(wā) ke māro hai.*
if farmer GEN near **donkey** AUX TOP 3 **donkey-DEF** ACC beat AUX

‘If a farmer has a donkey, he beats the donkey.’

¹¹cf. Jenks (2018: 510)

-wā as an Indexed Definite

- -wā definites must refer, i.e. they lack Coppock & Beaver's (2015) 'indeterminate readings'.

(25) CONTEXT: You are visiting another village, where you incorrectly assume that Ram is the village leader, and someone corrects you.

- a. *Rām mukhiyā nai hai. i gā-mā me koi*
Ram **village.leader** NEG COP DEM.PROX village-DEF in any
mukhiyā nai hai.
village.leader NEG COP

'Ram is not the village leader. This village doesn't have a leader.'

- b. *Rām mukhiya-wā nai hai. #i gā-mā me koi*
Ram **village.leader-DEF** NEG COP DEM.PROX village-DEF in any
mukhiyā nai hai.
village.leader NEG COP

'Ram is not the village leader. #This village doesn't have a leader.'

Deriving Anti-uniqueness from Indices

Proposal:

- Definites marked by $-w\bar{a}$ are dispreferred when a BN could be used instead.
- This preference for BN is due to *Minimize Restrictors!*.¹²

(26) *Minimize Restrictors!* (Schlenker 2005)

A definite description *the A B* (where the order of A vs. B is irrelevant) is deviant if A is redundant, i.e., if:

- the B* is grammatical and has the same denotation as *the A B* (=Referential Irrelevance), and
- A does not serve another purpose (=Pragmatic Irrelevance).

¹²See also: Minimize DP! (Patel-Grosz & Grosz 2017)

Deriving Anti-uniqueness from Indices

- Schlenker (2005) uses *Minimize Restrictors!* to explain why (27a) is infelicitous compared to (27b).

- (27) a. #the small American president
b. the American president

- *American president* already suffices to identify an referent (*small* is referentially irrelevant).
- Our proposal is that an index is irrelevant for determining the reference of a larger situation unique noun, similar to what Blumberg (2020); Ahn (2025) propose for English demonstratives.

- (28) a. # $\iota x.\text{sun}(x) \wedge x = y$ (-*waa* definite)
b. $\iota x.\text{sun}(x)$ (BN definite)

Deriving Non-honorificity from Indices

Proposal:

- The non-honorificity of *-wā* can be couched in a pragmatic theory of politeness.
- Wang (2023) derives honorific pronoun use from pragmatic maxims called *Taboos*, which prefer the use of presuppositionally weaker forms for honorification.
- For example: in languages that use a 2PL pronoun for 2SG honorification, this is due to the *Taboo on Atomicity*.

(29) *Taboo on Atomicity* (Wang 2024: 4)

In honorific contexts, use a form that refers to non-atomic entities.

- In languages with honorific 2PL (e.g., Russian Вы), this *Taboo* outranks *Maximize Presupposition!* in honorific contexts.

Deriving Non-honorificity from Indices

- We propose the *Taboo* below to derive non-honorificity with $-w\bar{a}$.

(30) *Taboo on Indices:*

In honorific contexts, use definite descriptions without indices.

- This is consistent with Wang's proposal that honorific forms should have weaker presuppositions.

(31) Presuppositions of plain/indexed definites

a. DEF: $\exists!x[P(x)]$

b. INDEXED DEF: $\exists!x[P(x) \wedge x = y]$

Deriving Non-honorificity from Indices

- The *Taboo on Indices* states that for honorification, one should use a plain definite instead of an indexed one.
- Thus, using an indexed definite in an honorific context explains why *-wā* can be interpreted as pejorative and affective.

Conclusion

An old debate:

- Definites encode uniqueness (Russell 1905).
- Definites encode familiarity (Heim 1982).
- Both are relevant and encoded differently (Schwarz 2009; Jenks 2015, 2018; Jenks & Konate 2022).

Some newer ideas: we don't need two types of definites if ...

- Definite marking presupposes anti-uniqueness (Owusu 2022);
- BN definites are quasi-names (Yip et al. 2023).

This study: a return to the older ideas.

- The unique/familiar distinction of Schwarz (2009) and Jenks & Konate (2022) can be maintained with anti-uniqueness and non-honorificity are derived pragmatically.
- Such an analysis extends to similar effects with other indexed definites (including demonstratives) cross-linguistically.

Acknowledgements

We'd like to thank Ram Charitra Sharma, Ram Khelawan Sharma, Rakesh Sharma, Ram Kumar, and Kumar Brajesh for their time and patience in providing Magahi judgements. We'd also like to thank Dorothy Ahn, Giuseppe Varaschin, the members of the MAL lab at Rutgers, and the audience at WCCFL 44 for their feedback on earlier versions of this work.

References I

- Ahn, Dorothy. 2017. Definite and demonstrative descriptions: a micro-typology. In *Proceedings of GLOW in Asia XI*, 33–48.
- Ahn, Dorothy. 2025. Definite expressions with and without deixis. In *Proceedings of WCCFL*, vol. 41, 1–17.
- Alok, Deepak. 2022. The discourse particle -waa in Magahi nominal domain. Talk at Language Diversity, Linuistic Theory, and Cultural Identity in South Asia, Yale University.
- Alok, Deepak & Bhalla Ojaswee. 2024. The syntax and semantics of honorific mismatches in Magahi. Presentation at the 38th South Asian Languages Analysis Roundtable, Nagaland University.
- Averintseva-Klisch, Maria. 2016. Demonstrative pejoratives. In *Pejoration*, 119–142. John Benjamins Publishing Company.
- Blumberg, Kyle Hammet. 2020. Demonstratives, definite descriptions and non-redundancy. *Philosophical Studies* 177. 39–64.
- Chierchia, Gennaro. 1998. Reference to kinds across language. *Natural Language Semantics* 6(4). 339–405.

References II

- Coppock, Elizabeth. 2024. Existence, uniqueness and familiarity. Talk presented at the 5th meeting of the DFG-funded scientific network 'Definiteness Across Domains', University of Ghana.
- Coppock, Elizabeth & David Beaver. 2015. Definiteness and determinacy. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 38. 377–435.
- Dayal, Veneeta & Li Julie Jiang. 2021. The puzzle of anaphoric bare nouns in Mandarin: A counterpoint to index! *Linguistic Inquiry* 1–20.
- Forson, Dufie Rebecca. 2022. *Syntax and semantics of multiple determiners in Akan*: University of Ghana MA thesis.
- Heim, Irene Roswitha. 1982. *The semantics of definite and indefinite noun phrases*. University of Massachusetts Amherst.
- Jenks, Peter. 2015. Two kinds of definites in numeral classifier languages. In *Semantics and Linguistic Theory*, 103–124.
- Jenks, Peter. 2018. Articulated definiteness without articles. *Linguistic Inquiry* 49(3). 501–536.

References III

- Jenks, Peter & Rassidatou Konate. 2022. Indexed definiteness. *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics* 7(1).
- Lakoff, Robin. 1974. Remarks on this and that. In *Proceedings of the chicago linguistics society*, vol. 10, 345–356.
- Owusu, Augustina P. 2022. *Cross-categorial definiteness/familiarity*. Rutgers University dissertation.
- Patel-Grosz, Pritty & Patrick G. Grosz. 2017. Revisiting pronominal typology. *Linguistic Inquiry* 48(2). 259–297.
- Potts, Christopher & Florian Schwarz. 2010. Affective ‘this’. *Linguistic Issues in Language Technology* 3.
- Roberts, Craige. 2003. Uniqueness in definite noun phrases. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 26. 287–350. doi:10.1023/A:1024157132393.
- Russell, Bertrand. 1905. On denoting. *Mind* 14(56). 479–493.
- Schlenker, Philippe. 2005. Minimize restrictors!(notes on definite descriptions, condition c and epithets). In *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung*, vol. 9, 385–416.

References IV

- Schwarz, Florian. 2009. *Two types of definites in natural language*: University of Massachusetts Amherst dissertation.
- Sharma, Aidan. 2025. Familiar definite marking in Magahi. In *Proceedings of Formal Approaches to South Asian Languages*, vol. 14, 222–241.
- Simpson, Andrew. 2005. Classifiers and dp structure in southeast asia. In Guglielmo Cinque & Richard S. Kayne (eds.), *The oxford handbook of comparative syntax*, 806–838. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Simpson, Andrew & Priyanka Biswas. 2016. Bare nominals, classifiers, and the representation of definiteness in Bangla. *Linguistic Analysis* 40(3-4). 167–198.
- Wang, Ruonan. 2023. Honorifics without [HON]. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 41(3). 1287–1347.
- Wang, Ruonan. 2024. Tiered honorification in Eastern Indo-Aryan: A [HON]-less proposal. In *Semantics and Linguistic Theory*, vol. 34, 1–20.
- Yip, Ka-Fai, Ushasi Banerjee & Margaret Chui Yi Lee. 2023. Are there “weak” definites in bare classifier languages? In *Semantics and Linguistic Theory*, vol. 33, 253–275.